



Playing catch up

Our first look at Internet Explorer 8 RC1 reveals a browser that's merely catching up to its competition; not blazing past

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No one is going to accuse Microsoft of being innovative with its Internet Explorer (IE) product. For all the progress that the company made in wrestling the browser crown from Netscape, so long ago, the software giant could until recently be described as sleeping at the wheel with IE. In the face of competition from Mozilla Firefox, Opera, Safari, and Chrome – Internet Explorer seems stuck in the stone-age, rubbing rocks while there's a space race in its backyard.

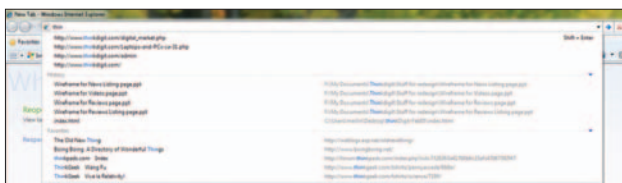
So what rouses a sleeping giant from its slumber? Is it losing 21 per cent of market share to an open-source alternative? Is it being considered outdated by web developers? Or is it being perceived as a security threat in an increasingly web-aware world?

Whatever the cause, the giant is awakening and version 8 is Internet Explorer finally getting with the times.

Let's take a quick tour of some features offered in this release.

Interface changes

The first noticeable change is that IE8 offers an address bar similar to that of Opera and Mozilla Firefox 3.x. Dubbed the Smart Address Bar; it matches what you type with URLs in your browsing history, along with searching content in your favourites. Another visible change is the page that's presented when you open a new tab: this page asks "What do you want to do next?"

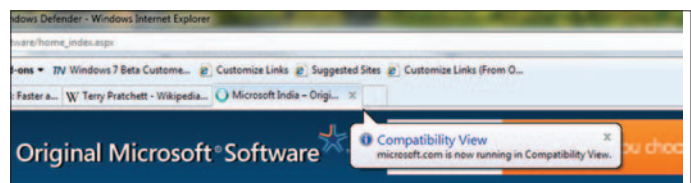


The Smart Address Bar offers suggestions from your browsing history, favourites, and feeds

and offers you sets of frequent tasks – such as opening recently closed tabs, browsing in private, or using a new feature called Accelerators. IE8 also offers a better zoom feature – one that (finally!) scales both the text and the image on a page. An interesting addition to version 8 is a feature called Caret Browsing. This is triggered when you press F7 and allows you to browse a web page sans mouse – the arrow keys allow you to browse a page like you would a text document. It's not nearly as useful as Opera's spatial navigation (using the SHIFT, S and W keys) but it is useful when you wish to highlight, copy-paste, or use Accelerators while reading text-heavy web sites, such as blogs.

Accelerators

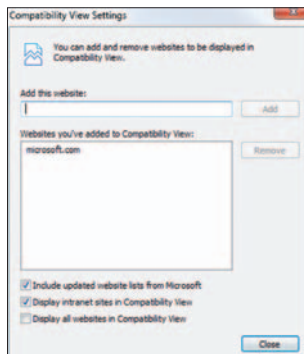
When you select text in IE8, a small icon is triggered. This icon, when clicked, reveals the various "Accelerators" that the browser offers. An Accelerator might offer to bring you an encyclopaedic entry on the selected text, or if the text is the name of a place, it could show you mapping information, or let you blog the selection, and so on. It is a convenient way to perform everyday tasks without the need to shuffle between web sites. As of now, most of the Accelerators point to Microsoft services – Encarta for the encyclopaedia, Live Spaces for blogging, Live Maps for mapping, and so on. However, IE8 allows you to use third-party accelerators which can be downloaded much like extensions for Firefox.



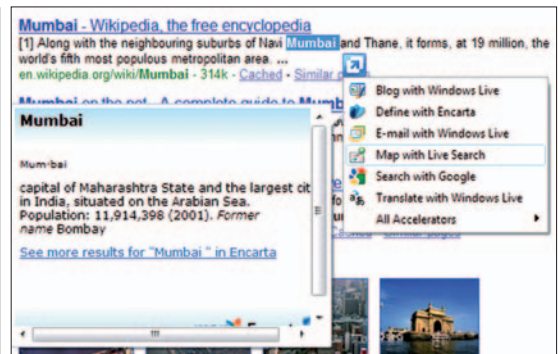
Clicking the icon runs the website in Compatibility View



An Accelerator that integrates mapping information with a keyword



Web sites that run under Compatibility View. Oh, the irony



MS Encarta integration offers information on Mumbai, also through an Accelerator